The Yuan dynasty maintained a large and strong navy and launched three major naval expeditions, two against Japan in 1274 CE and 1291 CE , and one against Java in 1292 CE . None of these expeditions was successful. The naval assaults against Japan were frustrated by inclement weather and the robust coastal defences put up by the Japanese. The inability of the Mongols to subdue Japan was ascribed by the inhabitants of the islands to the ‘kamikaze’ or the spirit winds that would always protect Japan. The expedition against Java had to be aborted as the hot and humid weather caused widespread sickness among the crews.

From the remains of some of these Chinese ships wrecked off the Japanese coast we obtain a glimpse of the advanced techniques used in the building and equipping of these ships. Among the items found in these shipwrecks are the remains of ceramic cannonballs with gunpowder enclosed in a porcelain casing.

We have seen that the Yuan dynasty, though originating in the dry steppes of Mongolia, realized the importance of maintaining a trading fleet and a powerful navy. Chinese domination of the maritime domain from the South China Sea to the western reaches of the Indian Ocean, which became manifest during the Southern Song dynasty, continued without challenge during the Yuan dynasty.

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China was only one segment of the Yuan empire and not considered by its rulers as the centre of civilization or the ‘Middle Kingdom’. The Confucian scholar-officials, particularly those from the previous Southern Song regime who had been consigned to the lower ranks in the Yuan hierarchy, never reconciled to Yuan rule though several were co-opted into its administrative and military machinery. Kublai Khan incorporated some Chinese court rituals into palace protocol and patronized Chinese writers and painters. However, Sinification did not progress very far, and the gulf between the rulers and their Chinese subjects remained. Subsequent Chinese annals dismiss the Mongols as barbaric and uncivilized and their rule over China as a major setback in the country’s culture and civilization.